



Understanding Grief

There is no right way to grieve — and you don't have to do it alone

Grief Is Natural

Grief is the natural response to losing someone or something important. It can follow death, the end of a relationship, job loss, a health diagnosis, or any major life change. There is no "right" way to grieve. Whatever you're feeling — sadness, anger, confusion, relief, numbness — it is valid.

Common Grief Responses

Emotional:

- Deep sadness, crying, or waves of intense emotion
- Anger at the situation, others, or the person who died
- Guilt or regret; anxiety about the future
- Relief (especially after long illness), which may bring its own guilt

Physical:

- Fatigue, low energy, or feeling physically heavy
- Changes in appetite or sleep; tightness in chest or stomach
- Weakened immune system

Cognitive and Behavioral:

- Difficulty concentrating, forgetfulness, or confusion
- Preoccupation with the loss or questioning meaning
- Withdrawing from people; restlessness
- Sensing the presence of the person who died

When Grief Gets "Stuck"

Most people gradually adjust to loss, though grief may come in waves for years. But sometimes grief becomes "prolonged" — staying intense for many months and making it hard to function. Signs include:

- Intense longing that doesn't ease over many months
- Difficulty accepting the loss or feeling "stuck" in disbelief
- Inability to engage in work, relationships, or daily life
- Feeling life has no meaning without the person
- Thoughts of wanting to die to be with them

If these feel familiar, please talk to a professional. Prolonged grief is treatable.

The Myth of Stages

You may have heard of the "five stages" — denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance. While these describe some experiences, grief doesn't follow a neat path. You might feel acceptance one day and deep sadness the next, or skip "stages" entirely. All of this is normal. Grief is not a checklist. It unfolds in its own time.

Self-Compassion During Grief

- 1. Let yourself feel:** Give yourself permission to grieve however comes naturally. No timeline, no "correct" emotion.
- 2. Take care of basics:** Eat, rest, drink water. Grief is exhausting and your body needs care.
- 3. Say no without guilt:** You don't owe anyone an explanation for needing space.
- 4. Keep connection open:** Stay in touch with at least one understanding person.
- 5. Honor the loss your way:** Write a letter, look at photos, visit a meaningful place, or sit with memories.

How Others Can Help

- Show up — send a message, make a call, bring food. Don't wait to be asked.
- Say the name of the person who died — it's comforting, not painful.
- Avoid cliches ("they're in a better place"). Instead: "I'm sorry" or "I'm here for you."
- Check in after the first weeks — support often fades when grief intensifies.
- Offer specific help: "I'm bringing dinner Tuesday" beats "Let me know if you need anything."

When to Seek Support

Grief is not a disorder, but you deserve support at any point. Consider reaching out if:

- Grief interferes with your ability to work, care for yourself, or maintain relationships
- You are using substances to cope
- You feel stuck, hopeless, or unable to see a future
- You are having thoughts of harming yourself

When to Seek Help

If you or someone you know is in crisis, please reach out:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988 (24/7)
Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741
Emergency Services	Call 911
SAMHSA Helpline	1-800-662-4357 (free, 24/7)

You don't have to face this alone. Help is available and recovery is possible.